

Session 21: The Valley of Dry Bones

Key Takeaways

- The Eden story establishes a thematic link between exile and death.
- Israel's history replays the Eden narrative, from God placing his chosen people in the land of blessing to their failure and exile from the land.
- The valley of dry bones is a metaphor where raising the dead to life points to new creation life in covenant restoration.

Translation and Literary Design of Ezekiel 37:1-14

¹ The hand of Yahweh was upon me,
and he brought me out by the **ruakh** of Yahweh,
and rested me in the middle of the **valley**,
and it was filled with **bones**,

² and he made me pass among them round and round,
and look, there were very many on the surface of the **valley**,
and look, they were very dry.

³ And he said to me,
"Son of a human,
can **these bones** **come to life**?"

And I answered,
"Lord Yahweh, you know."

⁴ And he said to me,
"**Prophecy** over **these bones**,
and say to them,

'O dry bones, hear the word of Yahweh.

⁵ Thus says Yahweh Elohim to these bones,
Look I will cause **ruakh** to enter you, so you can **come to life**,

⁶ **and I will put sinews on you,**
and I will make flesh come up over you,
and I will cover you with skin,

and I will put **ruakh** in you, so you can **come to life**,
and you will know that I am Yahweh."

7 And so I prophesied as I was commanded ,
and as I **prophesied** , there was a noise,
and look a shaking,
and the **bones** came together, **bone** to its **bone** ,
8 and I looked, and look: sinews were on them,
and flesh came up over them,
and skin covered them from above,
but **there was no ruakh in them** .

9 And he said to me,
“ **Prophesy** to the **ruakh** ,
Prophesy , Son of a human,
and say to the **ruakh** ,
'Thus says Yahweh Elohim,
Come from the four **rukhot** , O **ruakh** ,
and **breathe** on **these slain ones** ,
so they can **come to life** .”

10 And I prophesied as he commanded me ,
and **the ruakh entered into them** ,
and they **came to life** ,
and stood on their feet, a very great army.

11 And he said to me,
“Son of man,
these bones are the whole house of Israel;
look, they are saying,
'**Our bones** are **dried up** ,
and our hope has **perished** .
We are completely **cut off** .’

12 Therefore, **prophesy** and **you say to them** ,
' **Thus says Yahweh Elohim** ,
Behold, **I will open up your graves** ,
and **I will cause you to come up out of your graves, my people**;
and **I will bring you into the land of Israel** ,
13 **and you will know that I am Yahweh** ,
when **I have opened your graves** ,
and when **I have caused you to come up out of your graves, my people** .
14 and I will put my **ruakh** within you and you will **come to life** ,
and **I will rest you on your own land** ,
and you will know that I, Yahweh , have spoken and done it,'

declares Yahweh.”

Ezekiel 37:1-14. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).

The Resurrection of Israel

As a priest, Ezekiel would have been prohibited from contact with corpses and bones, but Yahweh gives him a thorough tour of a bone-littered valley ([37:1-2](#)). The question ([37:3](#)) borders on farce: “Can these bones live?” Ezekiel knows Yahweh as creator of all life, and he surely knows the rare stories of Yahweh reviving the recently dead ([1 Kgs. 17:17-24](#); [2 Kgs. 4:18-37](#)), but to resurrect and re-create new humans out of age-old scattered bones is beyond his comprehension.

[Ezekiel 37:5-10](#) is a remarkable scene with clear echoes of [Genesis 2:7](#). The new life of these long dead bones will be nothing other than an act of new creation, and the prominent role of God’s “spirit” (*ruakh*, used in all of its nuances of “spirit, wind, breath”) links back to the promise of [Ezekiel 36:26-27](#).

The Meaning and Significance of Ezekiel’s Vision

In [Ezekiel 37:11](#), Jerusalem has fallen, its people have been exiled in Babylon for who knows how long, and the hope of the exiles has vanished and despair has set in.

The only hope Israel has for future covenant relationship with Yahweh will be his life-creating power to completely resurrect the nation from “the grave” (= exile in Babylon) to new life in the promised land ([Ezek. 37:12-14](#)).

Resurrection in the Hebrew Bible

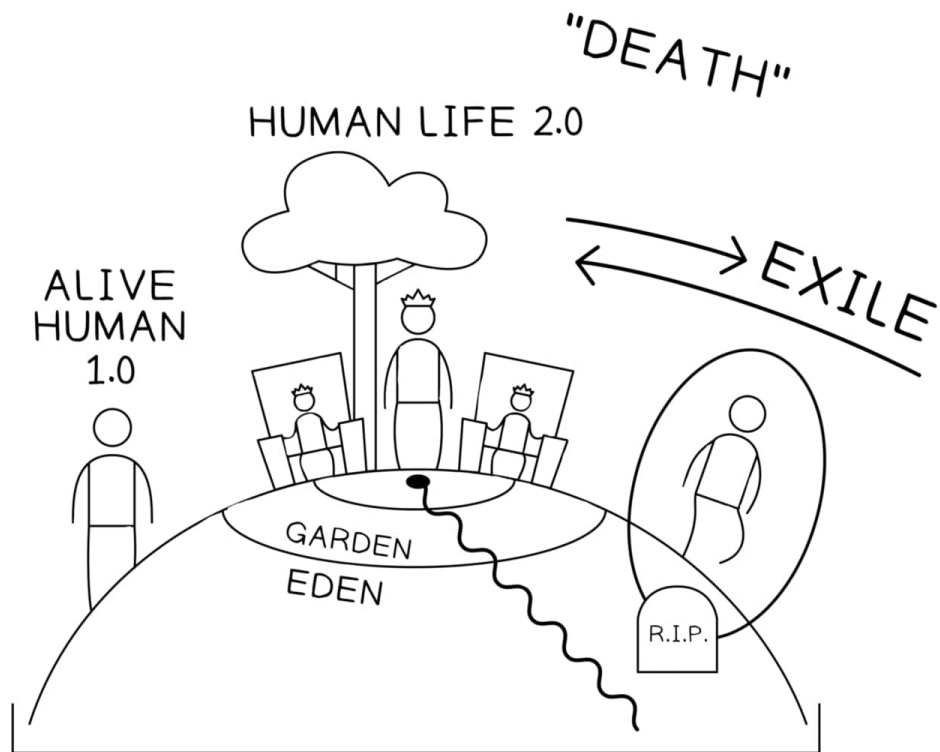
The Hebrew Bible contains many affirmations that Yahweh is not in competition with the gods of the underworld (Molech, etc.), and he alone is the God of the living and the dead ([Deut. 32:39](#); [1 Sam. 2:6](#); [Ps. 104:29-30](#)).

The Psalms contain a number of hopeful expressions that Yahweh’s faithfulness must extend beyond the grave ([Ps. 16:10](#), [49:15](#), [73:23-26](#)).

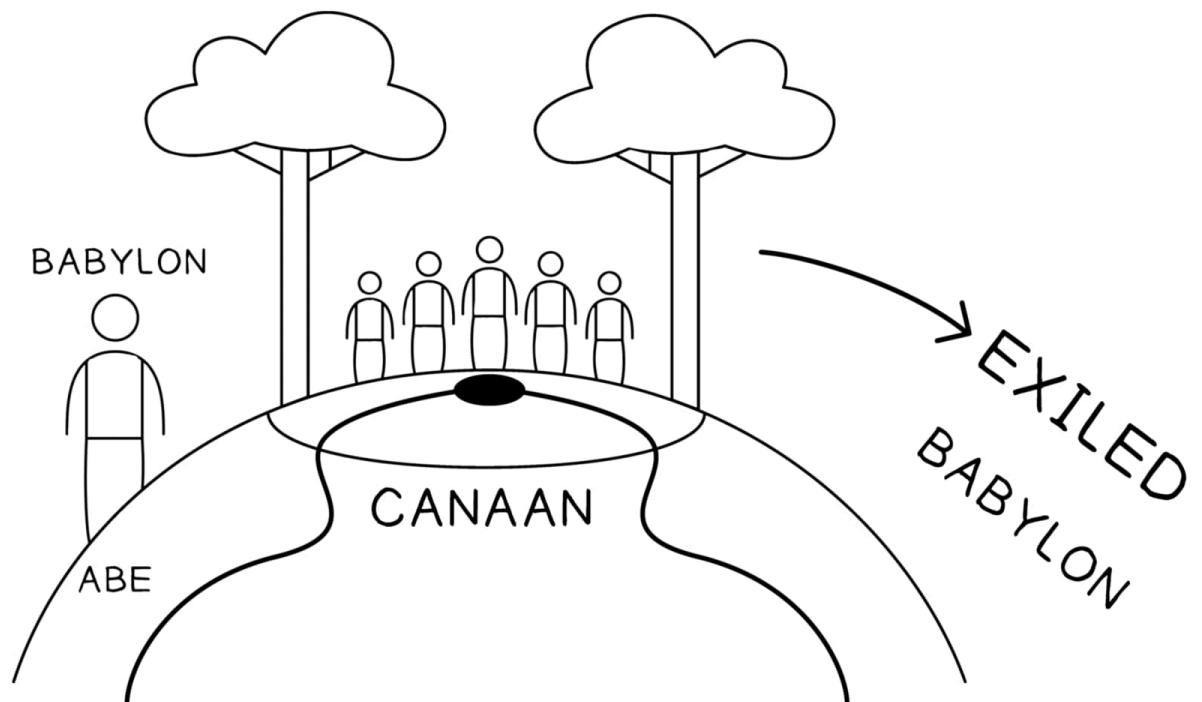
Other prophets pick up this imagery and use “death” as an image for exile and “resurrection” as an image for national and covenantal restoration ([Hos. 6:1-3](#), [13:14](#)).

Ezekiel’s use of resurrection imagery is symbolic of national and covenantal restoration (see [37:13](#)). But this chapter is a key link in the development of the idea that Israel’s restoration to fulfill the promises to Abraham would necessitate something like an actual resurrection of the dead for Israel first, then all humanity: [Isaiah 25:7-8](#), [26:19](#), and [Daniel 12:1-3](#).

Restoration of Israel as a Return to Eden



Restoration of Israel as a Return to Eden 1. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).



Restoration of Israel as a Return to Eden 2. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).

Reflection Question

How does the Eden story shape the prophetic imagination about exile and restoration?